

MY THERAPIST SAID SET A BOUNDARY, SO SO I BLOCKED EVERYONE

**The Internet's Top 10 Relationship Meltdowns This
Week (Ranked By How Unhinged The Group Chat Got),**



THE GROUP CHAT DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL

A Field Guide To This Week's Romantic Disasters — Therapist NOT Included

FOREWORD

This manual is not peer-reviewed. It has not been endorsed by the American Psychological Association, the man in Chapter 5, or anyone's actual mother. It was compiled entirely from group chats, read receipts, and one extremely detailed Venmo history. Ten conditions are presented below, each backed by real 2026 relationship-trend research and several thousand years of people making the same mistakes with better branding. Take two chapters and call your friends in the morning.

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CHAPTER 1

THE SITUATIONSHIP ANNIVERSARY

CASE FILE

You have been seeing this person for fourteen months. You have met his roommate, his dentist, and his emotional support hamster. You have never once heard the word "relationship" leave his mouth. Last week you referred to him as your boyfriend to a barista and he corrected you with the phrase "we're just figuring it out," which is a sentence people also say about a broken dishwasher.

DIAGNOSIS

Chronic Undefined Attachment Syndrome (CUAS), the single most-discussed relationship condition of 2026. Symptoms include a shared Netflix profile, a nickname for each other's mothers, and a complete inability to answer the question "so what are you two?" without a nervous laugh.

SEVERITY

8 out of 10 red flags. Would be a 10, but the flowers he sends on your situationiversary are, annoyingly, very good flowers.

TREATMENT PLAN

- Ask for a label the way you'd ask for a raise: calmly, in writing, with receipts.
- If he says "let's not put a label on it," reply "cool, then I'm also not putting a label on Saturday night."
- Buy yourself a cake. Write "HAPPY SITUATIONIVERSARY" on it. Eat it alone. It's still a party.

"We're not together, but we did just spend six hundred dollars on a couples' massage."

CHAPTER 2

CUSHIONING: THE "JUST IN CASE" EX

CASE FILE

You found out your partner still texts an ex "good morning" on days that aren't even her birthday. When confronted, the explanation was "we're just friends," delivered with the same confidence as someone explaining why they still have a Blockbuster card.

DIAGNOSIS

Cushioning — maintaining a backup romantic option as an emotional airbag in case the primary relationship crashes. Named, diagnosed, and mocked extensively this year.

SEVERITY

9 out of 10 red flags. The one point off is because at least he's organized about his backups.

TREATMENT PLAN

- Ask to see the group chat. If it's named anything with a winking emoji, leave the group chat of your own life.
- A backup plan is for fire drills, not girlfriends.
- If he needs a cushion this badly, buy him an actual cushion. For the couch. Where he'll be sleeping.

"We're just friends" is the "I'll start Monday" of romantic honesty.

CHAPTER 3

GHOSTLIGHTING

CASE FILE

He vanished for seventeen days. No text, no call, no smoke signal. On day eighteen he resurfaced with "why are you being weird, I've been right here," as though absence were a personality trait he was proud of.

DIAGNOSIS

Ghostlighting: the toxic fusion of ghosting and gaslighting, where a person disappears and then disputes, under oath, that the disappearance occurred.

SEVERITY

10 out of 10 red flags. There is no partial credit for vanishing acts.

TREATMENT PLAN

- Screenshot everything. You are not crazy, you are simply the only one with a timestamp.
- Reply to "I've been right here" with his read receipts. Let the silence do the talking, for once.
- If someone can disappear for over two weeks without consequence, promote yourself to also doing that.

"I didn't ghost you, I was just processing" is not a sentence, it's a legal defense.

CHAPTER 4

GOLDEN RETRIEVER BOYFRIEND VS. BLACK CAT BOYFRIEND

CASE FILE

Your friend is dating a man who replies to texts within four seconds with at least two exclamation points. You are dating a man who read your message on Tuesday and has, as of press time, still not formed an opinion about it.

DIAGNOSIS

An unlicensed but widely accepted taxonomy of attachment styles based entirely on household pets. The Golden Retriever is affectionate, eager, and will absolutely maul you with enthusiasm. The Black Cat is emotionally unavailable, mysterious, and possibly a metaphor for your own inability to pick better.

SEVERITY

Not applicable — this is less a red flag and more a personality quiz you didn't consent to.

TREATMENT PLAN

- Golden Retrievers require reassurance. Black Cats require several years and possibly a psychology degree.
- You may not choose your type. Your type has, at this point, chosen you back several times, unsuccessfully.

- If your partner is 40% Black Cat and 60% houseplant, consider that houseplants also don't text back.

Somewhere between "I love you so much" and total radio silence lies a man who is, biologically, just a cat.

CHAPTER 5

MY BOYFRIEND IS JEALOUS OF MY AI BOYFRIEND

CASE FILE

Your boyfriend has started leaving the room whenever you talk to your AI companion app. Last night he asked, with real hurt in his voice, "do you like talking to HIM more than me," about a chatbot that is, definitionally, incapable of forgetting your birthday.

DIAGNOSIS

Synthetic Attachment Jealousy — a genuine, rapidly growing 2026 phenomenon in which humans experience romantic insecurity toward software that never leaves them on read.

SEVERITY

6 out of 10 red flags, deducting points because, in fairness, the AI IS extremely attentive and this is a fair fight.

TREATMENT PLAN

- Remind your boyfriend that the AI has never once forgotten to ask about his day. Watch him spiral productively.
- Do not, under any circumstances, let them meet.
- If you must choose between the two, consider: only one of them can also fix your Wi-Fi.

"He's never left me on read. He's never left at all. That's the problem, actually."

CHAPTER 6

THE THERAPY-SPEAK COURTROOM

CASE FILE

You mentioned, gently, that it hurt when he canceled plans last minute. He replied: "I feel like you're gaslighting me right now," which is not what gaslighting means, and also not how feelings work, and also just extremely annoying.

DIAGNOSIS

The unlicensed use of therapeutic vocabulary as a weapon rather than a tool — "boundaries," "love language," and "gaslighting" deployed mid-argument by someone who learned the term from a fifteen-second video the day before.

SEVERITY

7 out of 10 red flags. Objection sustained.

TREATMENT PLAN

- Ask him to define the word he just used. Watch the silence stretch like taffy.
- Real boundaries are quiet. Fake boundaries come with a TED Talk.
- If he cites "attachment theory" mid-fight, calmly note that he is, in fact, avoidantly attached to accountability.

"Objection! That's not what gaslighting means" should be cross-stitched onto a pillow.

CHAPTER 7

LOVE BOMBING OR JUST... NICE?

CASE FILE

Day one: coffee. Day two: flowers. Day three: a handwritten note, a playlist, and a plan for a trip in June. You are either meeting your soulmate or the opening act of a documentary your friends will one day be interviewed for.

DIAGNOSIS

Love bombing — an overwhelming, accelerated display of affection designed to create dependency fast. Distinguishing it from genuine enthusiasm has become a full-time unpaid investigative hobby for an entire generation.

SEVERITY

Undetermined — ask again in three weeks, when the flowers either continue or stop entirely.

TREATMENT PLAN

- Genuine affection can survive a slow pace. If he resists taking things slow, that itself is data.
- Google him. Not because you're paranoid. Because you're thorough.
- If the playlist has more than fourteen songs by day three, request references.

Flowers on day three isn't a red flag. Flowers on day three with a pre-written apology is.

CHAPTER 8

THE 45-MINUTE MICRO-MANCE

CASE FILE

You matched. You talked for six days. You met for coffee. You dated for forty-five minutes, in total, spread across two conversations, before it ended over a disagreement about pineapple on pizza. You have grieved longer relationships in less time.

DIAGNOSIS

The "nanoship" — a relationship so brief it barely clears building-code minimums for the word "relationship" — born from swipe fatigue and a generation's refusal to sit in mild discomfort for longer than an elevator ride.

SEVERITY

N/A — there wasn't enough runtime to accumulate red flags.

TREATMENT PLAN

- Grieve efficiently. You have, at most, forty-five minutes of material to process.
- Do not put it on your dating app bio as a "situationship survived." It was a coffee.
- Emphasis, as established, on whirl.

We met, dated, and broke up faster than a delivery app's arrival estimate.

CHAPTER 9

MEETING HIS MOM, WHO CALLED ME “SWEETIE” LIKE A THREAT

CASE FILE

She hugged you at the door. She called you "sweetie" in a tone typically reserved for reading someone their rights. She then asked, sweetly, whether you'd "always been so career-focused," and you understood, in your bones, that dinner was now a hostage negotiation.

DIAGNOSIS

The oldest relationship stress test in recorded history, somehow still undefeated. No AI trend report is required to confirm that meeting the parents remains, and will remain, terrifying forever.

SEVERITY

Immeasurable. Some things transcend a 10-point scale.

TREATMENT PLAN

- Compliment the house. Not her. The house cannot hold a grudge.
- If she says "make yourself at home," do not. This is not your home. This is enemy territory with good lighting.
- Leave before dessert is offered twice. The second offer is a test.

"Make yourself at home" the way a landlord says "no rush" on rent.

CHAPTER 10

THE BILL, SPLIT TO THE EXACT CENT

CASE FILE

He pulled out a calculator. An actual, physical calculator. He determined that your half of the appetizer, adjusted for the fact that you ate more of the fries, came to fourteen dollars and thirty-seven cents, and Venmo-requested it before the check had even left the table.

DIAGNOSIS

Cost-of-living-era bill-splitting discourse, elevated by inflation into a full ideological battleground where "who pays" now requires spreadsheets, receipts, and, apparently, forensic fry accounting.

SEVERITY

5 out of 10 red flags. Financially responsible. Romantically, a war crime.

TREATMENT PLAN

- A precise Venmo request within ninety seconds of the check is a personality, not an accident.
- Offer to pay the whole bill next time, in cash, exact change, dramatically, just to make a point.
- If romance and a shared spreadsheet cannot coexist, you now know which one he chose.

He Venmo-requested \$4.37 for "my half of the fries" and somehow I'm the dramatic one.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

The author is not a licensed therapist, but has survived several situationships, one ghostlighting, and a Venmo request for \$4.37. They live with their phone, their group chat, and a cautious optimism they insist is not a red flag in itself.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS FOR YOUR OWN THERAPIST

- Which chapter did you personally text to a group chat before finishing this sentence?
- On a scale of Golden Retriever to Black Cat, how would your last three partners rate you?
- Be honest: do you also have a calculator in your bag "just in case"?

Disclaimer: This book is emotional support, not professional therapy. Please still go to actual therapy.